Meanwhile, tons of supplies, clothing and ammunition that had been painstakingly ferried into Tawang were now abandoned. Over 1,500 sleeping bags were piled in a corner of the helipad, where a Bell helicopter was left without any crew. The biggest casualty in the withdrawal was the 97 Field Battery—the towing vehicles and the guns got bogged down in the mud below the lower helipad and had to be left behind. Similarly, 116 Heavy Mortar Battery managed to bring the mortars down from Bum-la to Pankentang but could not carry them further. All the mortars had to be spiked and discarded. 1 Sikh too lost a great deal of its equipment during the withdrawal from Bum-la. Two guns of 2 (Derajat) Mountain Battery could not be recovered from Mukdang-la and were abandoned. 7 (Bengal) Mountain Battery, however, was the exception, as it successfully brought all the guns and mules down.

Mukdang-la was at a height of 12,500 feet, over which passed the track from Bum-la to Jang that bypassed Tawang altogether. Charlie Company of 4 Garhwal Rifles under the command of Major Hasta Bahadur Rai was holding this position. On 15 October, with two dozen men and two 3.7-inch guns (without ammunition) the gunners had joined the Garhwali troops on the pine-covered pass where they set up their gun positions amidst grazing yaks. On 23 October the commander of 2 (Derajat) Mountain Battery, Lieutenant Darshan Khullar, woke up to ‘the distant sound of artillery fire and realized that battle had broken out at Bum-la. A little later MMG bursts could also be heard. I was vaguely excited. I was certain that the Chinese were being given a bloody nose. I was certain that the Indian Army would, in keeping with its great exploits in the Second World War and the Kashmir operations, stand up resolutely in the face of a Chinese offensive. The thought that we would be asked to withdraw was unthinkable. I was obviously lost in blissful ignorance.’

By 1 p.m., both Rai and Khullar were told to abandon their positions at Mukdang-la at 5.30 that evening and make their way to Jang. Khullar’s guns were to be transported back loaded on mules, but the animal transport party was delayed. The mules eventually fetched up at Mukdang-la at 10 p.m., but by then it wore a deserted look with just the two spiked guns holding down the fort. The Chinese were nowhere to be seen either.

Through the night of 23-24 October, troops made their way down from Tawang and assembled at Jang, crossing over the Tawang Chu via Bridge 4. By 5 a.m., the rearguard of 4 Garhwal and 13 Dogra had also reported at